ROALLA



EXECUTIVE QUALIFICATION AND READINESS GUIDE

Canadian AI and Innovation Funding Qualification Guide 2026

A reusable decision framework for Canadian technology companies

Prepared for Canadian founders, chief executives, finance leaders, and technology executives

Prepared by ROALLA Transformation and Technology Advisory

Status date: 5 October 2026

Purpose

This guide helps management determine whether a company and a proposed project are ready for Canadian AI, innovation, R&D, commercialization, compute, and export support. It distinguishes hard eligibility gates from competitive strengths and shows where spend, revenue, headcount, operating history, matching funds, partnerships, and evidence affect the outcome.

Important notice

Funding eligibility, intake status, eligible costs, contribution terms, deadlines, stacking, and tax treatment must be confirmed directly with each program and the company's professional advisors. ROALLA does not guarantee funding and does not provide legal, tax, or accounting advice.

EXECUTIVE PERSPECTIVE

How to Use This Guide

The central question is not whether a company is generally innovative. It is whether a specific applicant, project, cost base, and timing window satisfy the rules of a specific program. Strong candidates manage funding readiness as an operating capability: they select projects deliberately, preserve evidence as work occurs, model their own cash requirement, and confirm terms before spending.

The Eight Qualification Gates

Gate	Decision area	What management must establish
1	Applicant	Legal form, Canadian presence and control facts
2	Scale	Headcount, revenue and related-company tests
3	History	Tax filings, financial records and operating evidence
4	Project	Incremental scope, milestones and Canadian benefit
5	Spend	Eligible cost categories, thresholds and timing
6	Capacity	Matching funds, working capital and delivery team
7	Evidence	Technical, financial, commercial and governance records
8	Route	Open intake, advisor validation, partners and submission plan

Three Executive Outcomes

PURSUE The hard gates are satisfied, evidence is credible, management can fund its share, and a current route is confirmed.

PREPARE The strategic fit is credible, but the company must close evidence, partner, financial, scope, or timing gaps before applying.

MONITOR The company or project does not currently meet a hard gate, or the program is closed. Preserve the project thesis and track the next intake or an alternative route.

Company age by itself is rarely the decisive test. What matters more often is whether the applicant has a completed tax year, verifiable revenue, credible financial statements, a delivery record, and sufficient cash to carry reimbursable costs. Some programs impose explicit revenue, headcount, project-spend, or matching-fund thresholds.

QUALIFICATION LOGIC

What Funding Qualification Actually Depends On

Factor	Effect	Where it matters	Evidence
Canadian legal presence	Often a hard gate	IRAP, CanExport, compute and regional programs	Articles, CRA business number, locations, ownership chart
For-profit status	Common hard gate for company funding	IRAP, CanExport, compute; varies by call	Corporate profile and tax status
Headcount	Explicit in several programs	IRAP and many SME routes generally cap at 500 FTE; CanExport uses 3 to 500 FTE	Payroll and FTE schedule
Revenue	Hard gate for some; strength for others	CanExport requires a defined revenue band; compute expects revenue and/or investor validation	Filed returns, financial statements, sales ledger
Years operating	Usually indirect rather than a universal minimum	Affects proof of revenue, filings, delivery record and financial capacity	Incorporation date, filed years, customer history
Eligible spend	Core driver of support	SR&ED, tax credits, compute, Scale AI, FedDev and project calls	Costed work plan, payroll, contracts, invoices

QUALIFICATION LOGIC CONTINUED

Spend, History and Capacity Dependencies

Factor	Effect	Where it matters	Evidence
Project size	Can be a hard threshold	Compute and FedDev have minimum project or contribution levels; cluster calls vary	Budget by category and fiscal year
Matching funds	Frequent hard gate	Scale AI, FedDev, compute and consortium projects	Cash-flow forecast, bank evidence, term sheets
R&D uncertainty	Hard technical test	SR&ED and an important IRAP consideration	Hypotheses, experiments, failures, results and time records
Partners	Mandatory or strongly preferred in collaborative routes	Scale AI, OCI and Global Innovation Clusters	Letters, roles, budgets, IP and data terms
Market evidence	Competitive strength and sometimes a threshold	IRAP, FedDev, Scale AI, compute and export programs	Pilots, pipeline, customer letters, pricing and forecast
Timing	Hard eligibility control	Most contribution programs exclude unauthorized or pre-agreement costs	Approval gates, contracts and purchase dates

Hard Gates Versus Competitive Strengths

Hard gates normally cannot be repaired through better writing. They include legal form, location, headcount or revenue bands, filing deadlines, minimum project size, eligible cost timing, and the applicant's required share. Competitive strengths improve selection but do not replace eligibility: executive sponsorship, customer validation, measurable outcomes, defensible IP, Canadian jobs, exports, responsible AI, and a credible team.

- Do not incur costs on the assumption that they will later be approved.
- Do not treat ordinary product development as experimental development without technical evidence.
- Do not count in-kind support as matching cash unless the current program explicitly permits it.
- Do not assume one project can receive the maximum stated support from every program; stacking rules and tax interactions apply.

PROGRAM QUALIFICATION MATRIX

Research and Development and Tax Routes

Program	Base qualification	Spend, revenue or history dependency	Readiness evidence and action
NRC IRAP and AI Assist	Canadian incorporated for-profit; generally 500 or fewer FTE; technology-driven innovation and Canadian economic benefit	Project costs and funding capacity matter; no universal revenue or company-age test published	Specific technical project, capable team and commercialization case. Engage now; support is discretionary.
SR&ED	Eligible work in Canada with technological uncertainty, systematic investigation and advancement; timely filing	Credit is calculated from eligible expenditures; not dependent on grant intake	Contemporaneous technical and financial evidence; claim generally due 18 months after corporate tax year-end. Operate continuously with tax review.
Ontario Innovation Tax Credit	Ontario permanent establishment; eligible Ontario SR&ED; federal ITC eligibility; filed T661; not tax-exempt	8% refundable credit on a shared expenditure limit up to $3 million; limit phases out with prior-year taxable income and taxable capital	CCPC and associated-company facts, Ontario costs and federal claim. Review with the SR&ED advisor.
Ontario Research and Development Tax Credit	Ontario permanent establishment and qualifying Ontario SR&ED expenditures	3.5% non-refundable credit; affected by eligible expenditure base and other assistance	Taxable income position, Ontario cost records and federal SR&ED support. Review with the SR&ED advisor.
OCI Collaborate 2 Commercialize	Ontario industry and eligible Ontario academic or research partner; current call rules apply	Industry cash contribution and project budget are program-specific	Research partner, commercialization problem, IP plan and work packages. Engage OCI and confirm an open call.

Tax Credit Threshold Note

For the Ontario Innovation Tax Credit, the expenditure limit is reduced when the prior taxation year's federal taxable income exceeds $500,000 and is eliminated at $800,000. It is also reduced when prior-year taxable capital exceeds $25 million and eliminated at $50 million. Associated corporations share the limit. These tests should be modelled by a qualified tax advisor using the current rules.

PROGRAM QUALIFICATION MATRIX CONTINUED

Commercialization, Compute and Export Routes

Program	Base qualification	Spend, revenue or history dependency	Readiness evidence and 2026 posture
Scale AI	Innovative collaborative AI project improving a value chain; more than one participant and at least one SME under 500 FTE	Reimburses up to 40% of eligible expenses for approved projects; applicant group funds the balance	Incremental AI, validated feasibility, executive support, business and ecosystem impact. Validate with the investment team.
FedDev Ontario RAII Adoption	Southern Ontario business with an incremental AI adoption project; intake rules apply	Latest intake: $125,000 to $5 million contribution request; up to 50% from FedDev and at least 50% applicant share; normally repayable for businesses	Measurable productivity outcomes, essential new costs and financing proof. Closed; prepare and monitor.
AI Compute Access Fund	Active Canadian for-profit under 500 FTE; Canadian R&D team and project; revenue and or Series A investor validation	Latest guide: $100,000 to $5 million eligible compute cost; cost share and Canadian-compute rules; reimbursement capacity required	Compute quotations, technical need, commercialization and Canadian benefit. Closed; quantify demand and monitor.
CanExport SMEs	Canadian for-profit with CRA number; 3 to 500 FTE; $300,000 to $100 million annual revenue; meaningful Canadian ties	Latest intake offered up to $50,000 for eligible export-development activities; company contribution required	Qualified new market, exportable offering, market plan and proof of revenue. Intake closed; use TCS now.
Ontario Critical Technologies	Eligibility flows through delivery partners and individual calls	Cost share, company size and project thresholds vary by call	Critical-technology commercialization and adoption outcomes. Monitor OCI and delivery partners.
Global Innovation Clusters	Membership, consortium and thematic requirements vary by cluster and call	Matching funds and eligible project spend are usually central; percentages vary	Collaborative industry project, Canadian ecosystem benefit, IP and commercialization plan. Pursue selectively.

Program figures above summarize official public guidance available on 5 October 2026 and are not an eligibility determination. A closed program remains useful for readiness planning, but management should not budget anticipated assistance until a current intake and project fit are confirmed.

COMPANY QUALIFICATION CHECKLIST

Corporate and Financial Readiness

- ☐ The applicant is an active Canadian-registered entity and its legal form is eligible for the target route.
- ☐ Ownership, associated companies, permanent establishments, operating locations and Canadian control facts are documented.
- ☐ Current FTE count and the calculation method are documented, including related entities where required.
- ☐ The last three fiscal years of financial statements, tax returns and current management accounts are available.
- ☐ Annual revenue can be substantiated using the form or period required by the target program.
- ☐ Taxable income and taxable capital tests have been reviewed for Ontario credit limits.
- ☐ Prior SR&ED claims, government assistance and contribution agreements are indexed.
- ☐ The company can fund its required share and carry reimbursable costs until claims are paid.
- ☐ The project budget separates eligible, potentially eligible and ineligible costs by fiscal year.
- ☐ No supplier contract, hiring commitment or project cost is assumed eligible before written authorization.

Operating History Test

Record the incorporation date, first commercial sale, completed tax years, filed financial history, customer deployments, recurring revenue history, and previous project delivery. A young company may still qualify where no minimum age is stated, but weak records or insufficient financing can make the project non-competitive or impossible to reimburse.

Financial Evidence to Prepare

Articles and CRA number; ownership chart; financial statements; corporate tax schedules; payroll and FTE schedule; revenue proof; bank evidence; financing letters; project cash-flow forecast; detailed cost assumptions; vendor quotations; and a government-assistance and stacking schedule.

PROJECT QUALIFICATION CHECKLIST

Technology, Commercialization and Governance Readiness

- ☐ The project solves a defined customer or operational problem and is not simply the company's full roadmap.
- ☐ The work is incremental, bounded by milestones and distinguishable from routine implementation or sales activity.
- ☐ Technical uncertainties, hypotheses, experiments, alternatives, failures and conclusions are recorded as work occurs.
- ☐ Engineering time and contractor costs can be traced to work packages and supporting evidence.
- ☐ A baseline and measurable outcome targets are defined for productivity, performance, revenue, jobs or exports.
- ☐ Customer interviews, pilots, letters of interest, contracts or adopter commitments support the market case.
- ☐ The company owns or has documented rights to background IP, data, models, software and third-party components.
- ☐ Partner roles, budgets, benefits, IP, data, confidentiality and commercialization rights are agreed in principle.
- ☐ Privacy, security, data residency, responsible AI, accessibility and human-oversight requirements are incorporated.
- ☐ An executive sponsor, project lead, finance lead, technical lead and commercialization owner are accountable.

Minimum Project Dossier

- Two-page project brief with problem, scope, novelty, customer, Canadian benefit and why support accelerates the work.
- Work-breakdown structure, milestones, risks, resourcing plan and costed budget.
- Technical evidence register and SR&ED-aligned recordkeeping process where applicable.
- Commercialization plan, outcome model, customer evidence and partner letters.
- Funding-stack model showing applicant cash, other government support, tax credits and timing.

MANAGEMENT SCORECARD

Funding Readiness Score

Score each item 0 for not established, 1 for partial, or 2 for complete and current. This is a management diagnostic, not a substitute for program eligibility review.

Readiness question	Evidence expected	Score
Eligible Canadian entity and location confirmed	Corporate records and program test	0 1 2
Headcount and revenue thresholds confirmed	FTE schedule and filed revenue evidence	0 1 2
Operating and tax history assembled	Statements, returns and customer history	0 1 2
Specific incremental project selected	Approved project brief	0 1 2
Eligible cost base mapped	Detailed budget and cost eligibility notes	0 1 2
Applicant share and working capital secured	Cash-flow model and financing evidence	0 1 2
Technical uncertainty or innovation case proven	Evidence register and architecture record	0 1 2
Commercial demand substantiated	Pilot, pipeline, letters or contracts	0 1 2
Partners and roles confirmed where required	Letters, roles, budgets and terms	0 1 2
IP, data, privacy and AI governance addressed	Rights register and governance review	0 1 2
Measurable outcomes and baseline defined	Benefits model and measurement plan	0 1 2
Current intake or advisor pathway confirmed	Written program source or advisor note	0 1 2
Stacking and tax interactions reviewed	Integrated assistance schedule	0 1 2
Evidence owners and cadence operating	RACI, meeting rhythm and repository	0 1 2
Executive go or no-go gate completed	Signed decision record	0 1 2

MANAGEMENT SCORECARD INTERPRETATION

How to Interpret the Result

Score	Posture	Management action
24 to 30	**PURSUE**	Proceed to program-specific validation and application planning. Close any remaining weaknesses before submission.
15 to 23	**PREPARE**	Strategic potential exists, but evidence, financing, partners, governance or scope need focused work.
0 to 14	**MONITOR**	Do not rush an application. Resolve hard gates, select a better project, or monitor a more suitable route.

Automatic Stop Conditions

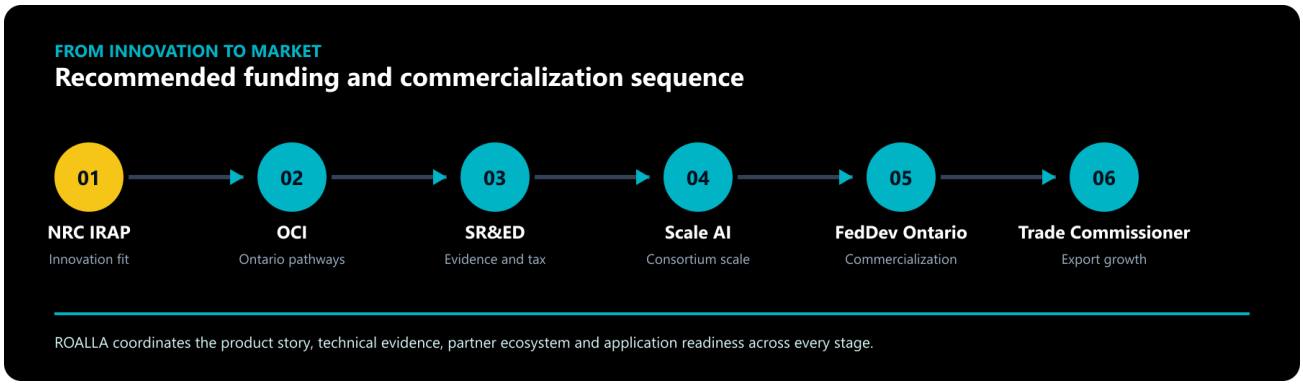
- The applicant fails a published legal, geography, headcount, revenue or filing-deadline requirement.
- The company cannot provide its share of project costs or carry reimbursement timing.
- The project is already substantially committed and the program does not permit retroactive costs.
- Required partners, customer permissions, data rights or IP arrangements cannot be secured.
- The expected funding is being used to make an otherwise non-viable product or project appear viable.
- Management cannot assign accountable owners for evidence, delivery, claims and compliance.

When to Override the Numeric Score

A single hard eligibility failure overrides a high score. Conversely, a low early-stage score does not mean the opportunity should be abandoned; it means management needs a structured readiness period or a different program. ROALLA should document the decision, assumptions, evidence gaps and next review date.

Recommended Sequence

For a Canadian technology SME, the default relationship sequence is NRC IRAP, then OCI, followed by an SR&ED and Ontario tax-credit review, then Scale AI, FedDev Ontario, and the Trade Commissioner Service. The order should change when project type, geography, export timing, compute intensity or an active call creates a more urgent route.



READINESS OPERATING PLAN

Recommended 90 Day Qualification Sprint

Timing	Stage	Core work	Output
Weeks 1 to 2	Baseline	Confirm entity, ownership, FTE, revenue, fiscal history, prior assistance, cash capacity and candidate projects.	Eligibility fact base
Weeks 2 to 4	Select	Screen projects against hard gates, technical evidence, commercial value, costs, partner needs and program timing.	Priority project and reserve route
Weeks 4 to 6	Structure	Build scope, work packages, budget, eligible-cost map, benefits baseline, risk register and evidence plan.	Investment-ready project dossier
Weeks 6 to 8	Validate	Engage IRAP, OCI, tax advisor and other program contacts; test partner and customer interest.	Validated assumptions and gap list
Weeks 8 to 10	Prepare	Secure letters, financing evidence, quotations, governance documents and submission-ready narratives.	Reusable data room
Weeks 10 to 12	Decide	Complete executive go or no-go review; approve application, readiness extension or monitoring plan.	Decision record and 12-month calendar

Data Room Index

- 01 Corporate and ownership 02 Financial and tax 03 People and payroll 04 Project and architecture
- 05 Technical evidence 06 Budget and quotations 07 Customers and market 08 Partners and agreements
- 09 IP data privacy and security 10 Responsible AI 11 Funding stack and prior assistance 12 Decisions and claims

Ongoing Cadence

Review the opportunity portfolio quarterly, the evidence register monthly, and active project records at least biweekly. Reconfirm program status before each material spend or submission decision. Keep a written record of advisor guidance; verbal discussions are useful but do not replace program terms or a contribution agreement.

ROALLA ADVISORY MODEL

How ROALLA Can Help

ROALLA acts as the technology and commercialization advisor coordinating the full readiness system. The objective is not to maximize applications. It is to direct management effort toward projects that are strategically sound, evidence-ready, financeable and aligned to the most credible support route.

ROALLA workstream	Executive value
Qualification diagnostic	Test the company and project against hard gates, thresholds, intake timing and competitive criteria.
Product roadmap alignment	Convert business priorities into bounded, sequenced AI and technology investments.
Funding architecture	Map direct funding, tax credits, compute, collaboration and export support; model timing and stacking.
Technology architecture	Define data, model, integration, cloud, compute, observability, security and deployment decisions.
AI strategy and governance	Prioritize use cases and establish evaluation, human oversight, privacy, responsible AI and model-risk controls.
Partner and vendor ecosystem	Coordinate customers, adopters, researchers, clusters, cloud and model vendors, and delivery partners.
Application readiness	Build project briefs, work plans, budgets, outcome models, evidence registers, partner materials and executive gates.
Ongoing monitoring	Maintain the opportunity calendar, screen new calls and bring decision-ready options to management.

Recommended Initial Mandate

- Four-week company and project qualification diagnostic using this guide.
- Prioritized program map with proceed, prepare and monitor decisions.
- One flagship project dossier, financial and evidence model, and two reserve concepts.
- Facilitated advisor conversations and a twelve-month readiness calendar.
- Executive briefing with clear decisions, owners, risks and next actions.

CONTROL FRAMEWORK

Key Risks and Controls

Risk	Exposure	ROALLA control
Availability	Program budgets, calls and criteria change.	Confirm current terms directly and maintain alternatives.
Eligibility	A strong story cannot cure a failed hard gate.	Use a documented program-specific checklist before drafting.
Cost timing	Pre-approval costs may be ineligible.	Gate contracts, hiring and purchases against written authorization.
Cash flow	Reimbursement and repayable support can strain liquidity.	Model applicant share, claim timing, holdbacks and repayment.
R&D evidence	Routine development or weak records can fail review.	Capture uncertainty, experiments, failures, conclusions and costs contemporaneously.
Stacking	Other assistance can reduce support or tax-credit bases.	Maintain one integrated assistance and expenditure schedule.
Partnerships	Unclear IP, data or budgets can stall collaborative projects.	Agree roles, rights, contributions and commercialization terms early.
AI governance	Privacy, bias, security, accuracy and data rights can undermine adoption.	Build responsible AI and risk controls into project scope and evidence.
No guarantee	Programs are competitive and discretionary.	Treat support as an accelerant, not the basis of commercial viability.

Professional Advice

Qualified tax, legal and accounting advisors should validate SR&ED and provincial credits, financial reporting, contribution treatment, contracts, privacy, data, intellectual property and regulatory matters. ROALLA coordinates these inputs with the product, architecture, commercialization and funding strategy.

OFFICIAL EVIDENCE BASE

Selected Official Sources

These sources support the qualification factors summarized in this guide. Program administrators retain sole discretion and current terms must be reconfirmed before acting.

NRC IRAP financial support. Official source — Applicant and SME criteria.
NRC IRAP AI support. Official source — AI Assist context.
CRA SR&ED eligibility. Official source — Eligible work and exclusions.
CRA SR&ED filing requirements. Official source — Claim forms, evidence and deadlines.
Ontario Innovation Tax Credit. Official source — Rate, expenditure limit and income and capital phase-outs.
Ontario R and D Tax Credit. Official source — Ontario eligibility and non-refundable credit.
Scale AI projects. Official source — Collaboration, readiness and up to 40% reimbursement.
FedDev Ontario RAII Adoption funding. Official source — Latest intake amounts, cost sharing and repayment.
AI Compute Access Fund guide. Official source — Applicant, project-cost and cost-share requirements.
CanExport SMEs 2026 to 2027 guide. Official source — Revenue, headcount and applicant criteria.
OCI Collaborate 2 Commercialize. Official source — Industry and Ontario research collaboration.
Ontario Critical Technologies Initiatives. Official source — Delivery-partner and call framework.
Global Innovation Clusters. Official source — Cluster and collaborative project context.

Advisory Disclaimer

This ROALLA guide uses official public information available as of 5 October 2026. It is a strategic readiness and marketing document, not an offer, approval, eligibility determination, legal opinion, tax opinion, accounting opinion or assurance of funding. Program administrators may change terms and retain sole discretion. The company must confirm current program rules, validate its facts and obtain appropriate professional advice before acting.

